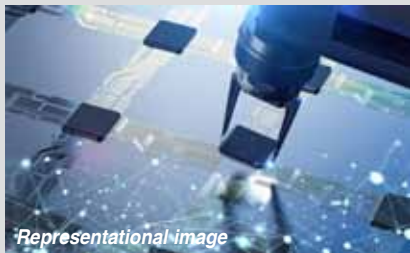


INTERNATIONAL news

ESIA urges Europe to strengthen semiconductor policy

The European Semiconductor Industry Association (ESIA) has called on the EU to adopt a 10-year semiconductor strategy backed by a dedicated budget under the European Competitiveness Fund. As the EU reviews the Chips Act, ESIA urges faster permitting, stronger industry involvement, aligned R&D priorities, talent development, and expanded state-aid frameworks to boost investment, innovation, and supply-chain resilience.



Representational image

Nokia commits \$4 billion to expand US operations

Nokia will invest \$4 billion to expand US manufacturing and R&D and accelerate the development of AI-ready networks. About \$3.5 billion will go to future-oriented connectivity and AI research, while \$500 million supports domestic production. The plan aligns with rising global demand for artificial intelligence (AI) and includes work on 5G, 6G, and AI-integrated network technologies.

EIB and STMicroelectronics seal €1 billion funding deal

The European Investment Bank has signed the first €500 million tranche of a €1 billion financing package with STMicroelectronics to strengthen Europe's semiconductor ecosystem. The funding will expand manufacturing in Italy and France, direct 60% towards high-volume production, support advanced R&D, and reduce Europe's reliance on external chip suppliers.

Wolfspeed secures \$698.6 million CHIPS Act tax refund after bankruptcy

Wolfspeed has secured \$698.6 million in CHIPS Act tax refunds, boosting liquidity following its emergence from bankruptcy. Its cash balance now stands at \$1.5 billion. The funds will support the transition from 150mm to 200mm silicon carbide wafers and repay \$175 million in debt. Wolfspeed is scaling production for EV, AI, aerospace, and energy markets.

Ford and SK On to unwind \$11.4 billion battery venture in the US

Ford Motor Company and SK On will dissolve their \$11.4 billion BlueOval SK EV battery joint venture and restructure ownership of three planned US plants. Ford will take control of two Kentucky facilities, while SK On will operate the Tennessee site independently. The move reflects slower EV demand and delayed capacity needs, though both firms will continue battery supply ties and long-term electrification plans.

Trump administration to invest \$150 million in chip-laser startup xLight

The US will invest up to \$150 million in chip-laser startup xLight to advance energy-efficient free-electron lasers for EUV lithography. The funding, the first from the revamped CHIPS research office, supports work with national labs and leadership under Pat Gelsinger as the US moves to rebuild its advanced semiconductor manufacturing edge.

Critical Manufacturing to power Black Semiconductor's new fab in Germany

Black Semiconductor has chosen Portugal-based Critical

Manufacturing to provide the MES and automation platform for FabONE, its fully automated 300mm pilot fab in Aachen. The facility will scale graphene-based chip interconnects and deploy a full MES suite with IoT integration and AI-driven analytics. The partnership strengthens Europe's semiconductor ambitions and supports Black Semiconductor's move toward high-volume production.

Taiwan clears Nvidia's \$31 million investment for new office

Taiwan has approved Nvidia's plan to invest more than \$31.8 million in a new subsidiary and office complex, thereby expanding its presence in Taipei. The move supports rising demand for AI processors and deepens Nvidia's partnership with TSMC. The investment will enhance engineering, supply chain and support functions, reinforcing Taiwan's semiconductor leadership.

Merck invests €500 million in Taiwan's chip materials facility

Merck has opened a €500 million semiconductor-materials complex in Kaohsiung, Taiwan. The 150,000-square-metre site will produce thin films, formulation materials, and specialty gases, creating 150 high-tech jobs. Built to LEED Gold standards and equipped with digital twin systems, it strengthens Asia's supply resilience ahead of 2026 volume production under Merck's global expansion programme.

Congatec and Qualcomm unite to power the next tech wave

Congatec and Qualcomm have partnered to advance high-performance embedded edge AI systems for industrial applications. The collaboration integrates Qualcomm's Dragonwing processors with Congatec's COM HPC mini modules, enabling compact, energy-efficient devices. Designed to handle demanding industrial workloads, the initiative delivers high compute density, low power consumption, and robust connectivity, driving the next generation of edge AI and industrial PC solutions.

Navitas signs distribution deal with WT Microelectronics to streamline Asian operations

Navitas has expanded its partnership with WT Microelectronics to unify Asian distribution for its GaNFast GaN and GeneSiC SiC power devices, strengthening support for AI data centres, HPC, energy infrastructure, and industrial electrification. WT will lead design and logistics, improving delivery speed and customer access.

Arm and South Korea to strengthen semiconductor and AI capabilities

Arm and South Korea have signed an agreement to strengthen semiconductor and AI capabilities, including a chip design school to train about 1400 specialists. Arm will support advanced chip-design education as South Korea targets a top-three global AI position. The deal follows major AI chip commitments from Samsung, SK Hynix, and Nvidia, reinforcing the country's innovation push.

Vietnam attracts new gaming hardware manufacturing investments

Foxconn and Luxshare plan major expansions to boost Vietnam's gaming hardware manufacturing. Foxconn units aim to add up to 4.8 million Xbox consoles yearly, while Luxshare proposes producing about 4.5 million game consoles at a new facility. The move strengthens Vietnam's role in the global supply chain as firms diversify beyond China.